Historic Reimaginings

From Artifact to Story Using Responsible AI

“Open the pod bay doors, HAL.”

“I’m sorry, Dave. I’m afraid I can’t do that.”

— *2001: A Space Odyssey* (1968)

“The development of full artificial intelligence could spell the end of the human race.”

— Stephen Hawking 2014

“I am an optimist and I believe that we can create AI for the good of the world.”

— Stephen Hawking 2017

“With artificial intelligence we are summoning the demon.”

— Elon Musk 2014

“AI is just an incredibly helpful, useful thing.”

— Elon Musk 2026

“We may wish we'd never seen that genie.”

— Warren Buffett 2024

“If it's used in a pro-social way, it's got terrific benefits to society.”

— Warren Buffett 2023

“The problem is I really don't know anything about AI.”

— Warren Buffett 2024

“It is like a devious child.”

— *My Realtor*

“Mitigating the risk of extinction from AI should be a global priority…”

— Sam Altman, CEO of OpenAI, creator of ChatGPT, 2023

“Aric Wilmunder was a computer programmer and game developer known for his work in the video game industry… unfortunately, he passed away on January 2, 2018.”

— ChatGPT

“The thoughts of our ancestors, locked in mud and ash for 2000 years, hidden in darkness…

Finally, after 275 years, we can begin to read the scrolls”

— Vesuvius Challenge 2024

From Fear of Replacement to Responsible Use

2023–2024

Can we trust it?

Historical authority, misinformation, ethics, and early experimentation.

2025–2026

How can we use it responsibly?

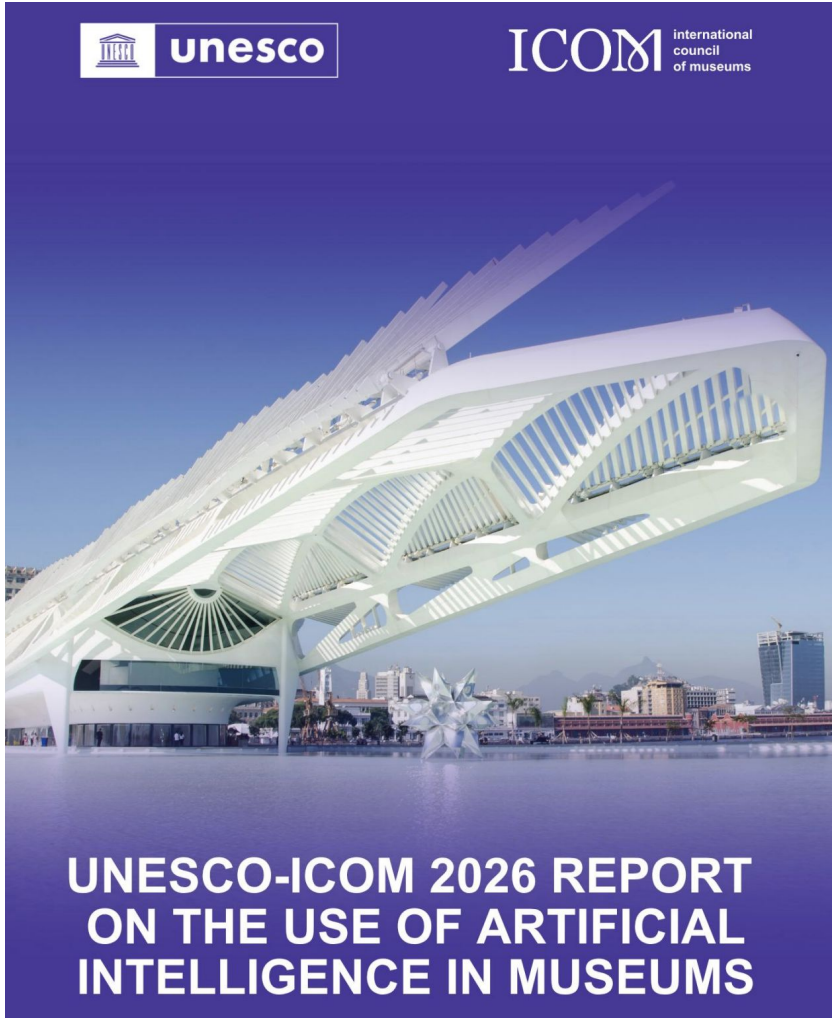
Research assistance, collections, interpretation, accessibility, and human oversight.

The historian isn't being replaced. The historian is learning to use a new tool.

Themes illustrated by NCPH, AHA, MuseumNext, Cambridge University Press, and heritage research publications.

So Where do Museums Stand Today?

Survey of 403 museums in 90 countries



What Did the Survey Reveal?

57%

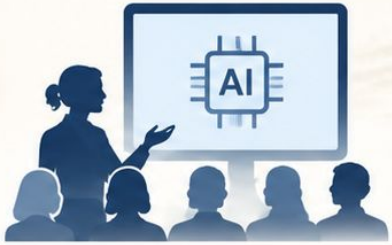
Already using AI

Artificial intelligence is becoming part of everyday museum operations.

55%

Lack internal AI policies or guidelines

Institutional governance is lagging behind adoption.



17%

Provide AI training for staff

Most responding museums have yet to establish formal AI training.

AI adoption is advancing faster than institutional preparedness.

How Are Museums Using AI?

Most common applications reported by survey participants.

70%

Administration

Operational tasks, planning, reporting, and staff productivity.

62%

Communications

Content creation, marketing, social media, and audience engagement.

43%

Research & Documentation

Collection research, cataloging, transcription, and information analysis.

Exhibition Development | **Visitor Engagement** | ...

Other reported uses include exhibition development and visitor engagement.

Use is broad and growing, from internal operations to public-facing programs.

What Concerns Museums Most?

Key concerns raised by survey participants (UNESCO–ICOM).

Accuracy & Reilability

Risk of incorrect or misleading information (“hallucinations”).

Copyright & Intellectual Property

Use of collections, images, and content in AI systems.

Data Protection

Safeguarding sensitive data, including cultural and community information.

Transparency

Being clear about when and how AI is used, and its limitations.

Bias

Potential for biased or unrepresentative results in AI outputs.

These concerns go beyond technology — they are about maintaining public trust in museums.

UNESCO–ICOM Conclusion

*A Call for **Responsible AI Use***

Training & Capacity Building

Equip museum professionals with the skills to evaluate and use AI.

Governance & Ethical Guidelines

Establish clear institutional policies and accountability.

Collaboration & Knowledge Sharing

Help museums learn from one another and share resources.

Human Oversight

Preserve professional judgment, historical accuracy, and public trust.

Responsible AI use requires more than technology.
It requires informed people and institutional safeguards.

The question is no longer whether AI is trustworthy, it isn't. The question has become how to harness its remarkable capabilities responsibly, despite its limitations.

ATARI
LUCAS Arts
3DO
danger inc.
Microsoft
ERICSSON
Afero
DARPA
ATARI
HELLO TOMORROW
GAMES PEOPLE PLAY
STORIES WORLDS IMAGINATION
INTERACTIVE ENTERTAINMENT AT HOME
PEOPLE MOBILE POSSIBILITIES
SOFTWARE FOR A MORE CONNECTED WORLD
PEOPLE IDEAS NETWORKS
A SMARTER PHYSICAL WORLD
BOLD IDEAS FOR A MORE RESILIENT TOMORROW
DIFFERENT WORLDS. A COMMON THREAD.
PLAY • CREATIVITY • PEOPLE • TECHNOLOGY • WHAT'S NEXT

“I was just looking for a gift for my wife”

4437 | ☆

(LOT OF 6) COLLECTION OF SAMPLERS

LIVE AUCTION

November 14th Jewelry, Art, Furniture, Asian

Location

Clars Auction Gallery 5644 Telegraph Ave. Oakland, CA 94609

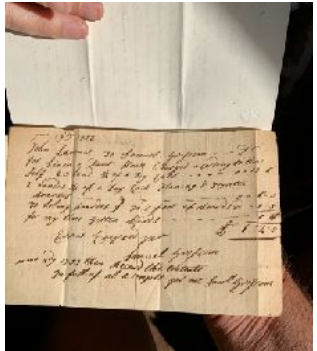
Description

(lot of 6) Collection of Samplers, including one by Ann H. Ganby, with the alphabet above various floral decorations and inscribed "Patience will wipe away the streaming team, and hope will paint the pallied cheek of fear, contept (sp.) will always happiness supply, and virtue calls a blessing from on high," etc.

Condition

Detailed condition reports are not included in this catalog. For additional information, including condition reports, please contact us at online@clars.com. The absence of a condition statement does not mean

CAROLINE L. PRESCOTT



Crafting a Nation, Stitch by Stitch

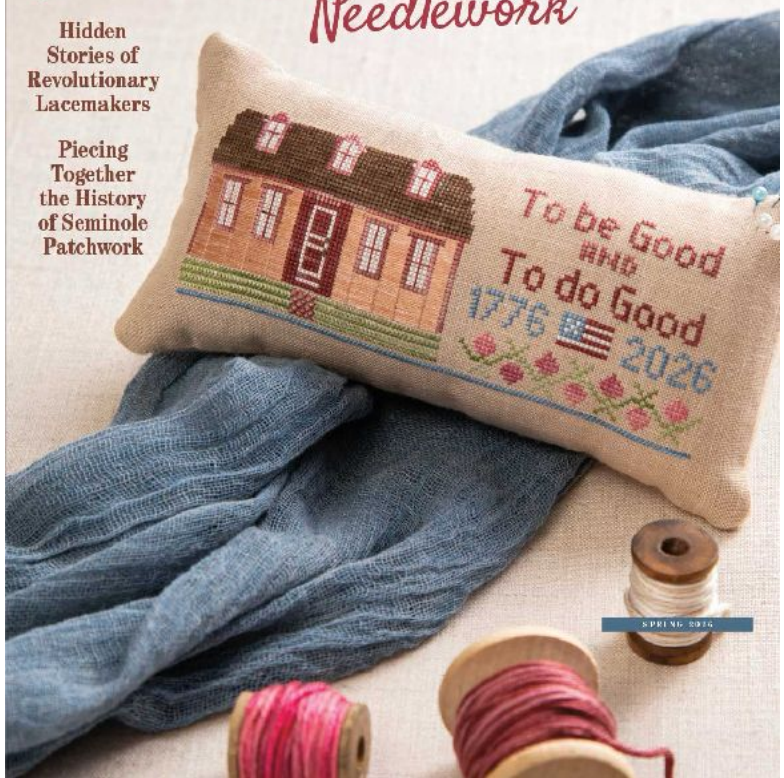
All This By Hand

PIECEWORK

Celebrate American Needlework

Hidden Stories of Revolutionary Lacemakers

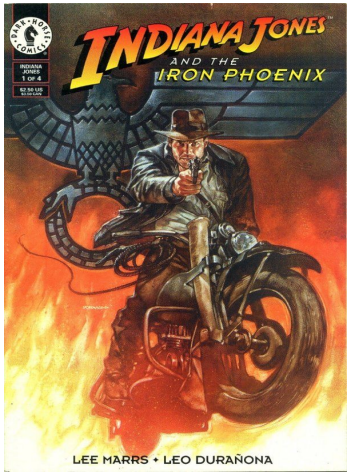
Piecing Together the History of Seminole Patchwork



SPRING 2026

LUCAS
Arts
MONTH

HUMONGOUS ENTERTAINMENT
CONTINUE
www.humongous.com

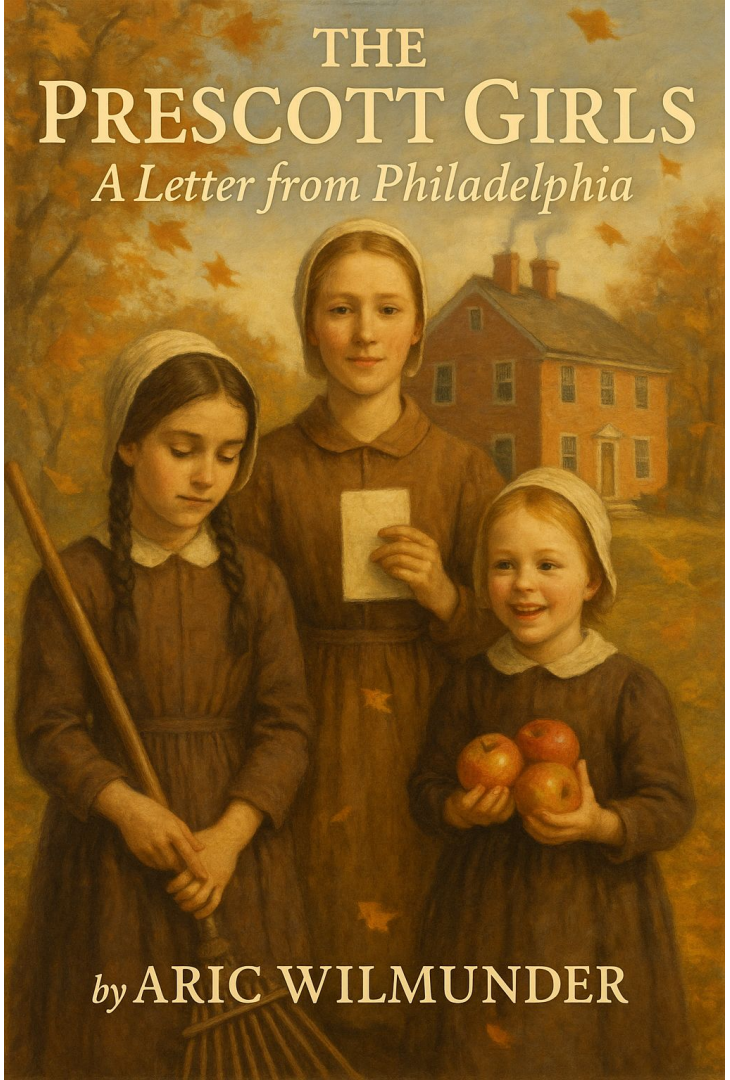

INDIANA JONES
AND THE
IRON PHOENIX
LEE MARRS • LEO DURAÑONA

INDIANA JONES
AND THE
IRON PHOENIX
LEE MARRS • LEO DURAÑONA

INTERNATIONAL
SLOPE RACES
IT'S MAN-ON-MAN RACING AT DAVENPORT

THE LION, the WI
and the WARDR
SCHOLASTIC
A. A. M
WHEN
WERE
YOUN
DECORATIO
Ernest H. Sh
The Borrowers
MARY NORTON
Winnie-the-Pooh
Tik-Tok of
OZ
By L. Frank Ba
LITTLE HOUSE IN THE BIG WOODS
"All winter," Pa said. "Grandpa has been
making wooden buckets and little troughs. He
made them of cedar and white ash, for those
woods won't give a bad taste to the sap or
syrup.
"To make the troughs, he split out flat
sticks as long as my hand and as big around as my
fingers. Near one end, Grandpa cut the stick
half through, and split one half off. Then
him a flat stick, with a square stick at one
end. Then with a bit he bored a hole engl
wise through the square part, and with his
knife he whittled the wood till it was only
thin shell around the round hole. The flat pa
of the stick he hollowed out
with his knife till it was a li
tle trough.
"He made dozens of thes
and he made ten new wood
LITTLE HOUSE IN THE BIG WOODS
buckets. He had them all ready when the first
warm weather came and the sap began to
move in the trees.
"Then he went into the maple woods and
with the bit he bored a hole in each maple
tree, and he hammered the round end of the
little trough into the hole, and he set a cedar
bucket on the ground under the flat end.
"The sap, you know, is the blood of a tree.

A B C D E F
G H I J K L
M N O P Q
R S T U V
W X Y Z


THE
PRESCOTT GIRLS
A Letter from Philadelphia
by ARIC WILMUNDER

AI changes the economics of iteration

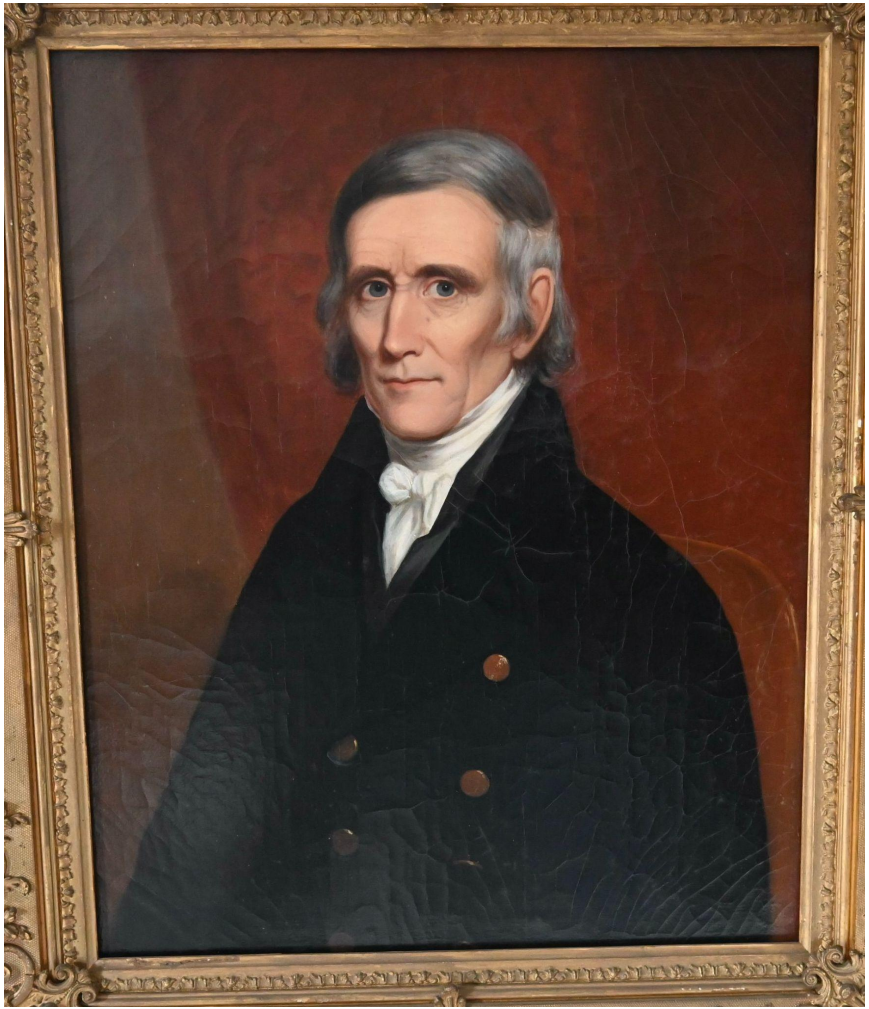
BECKIE PRESCOTT

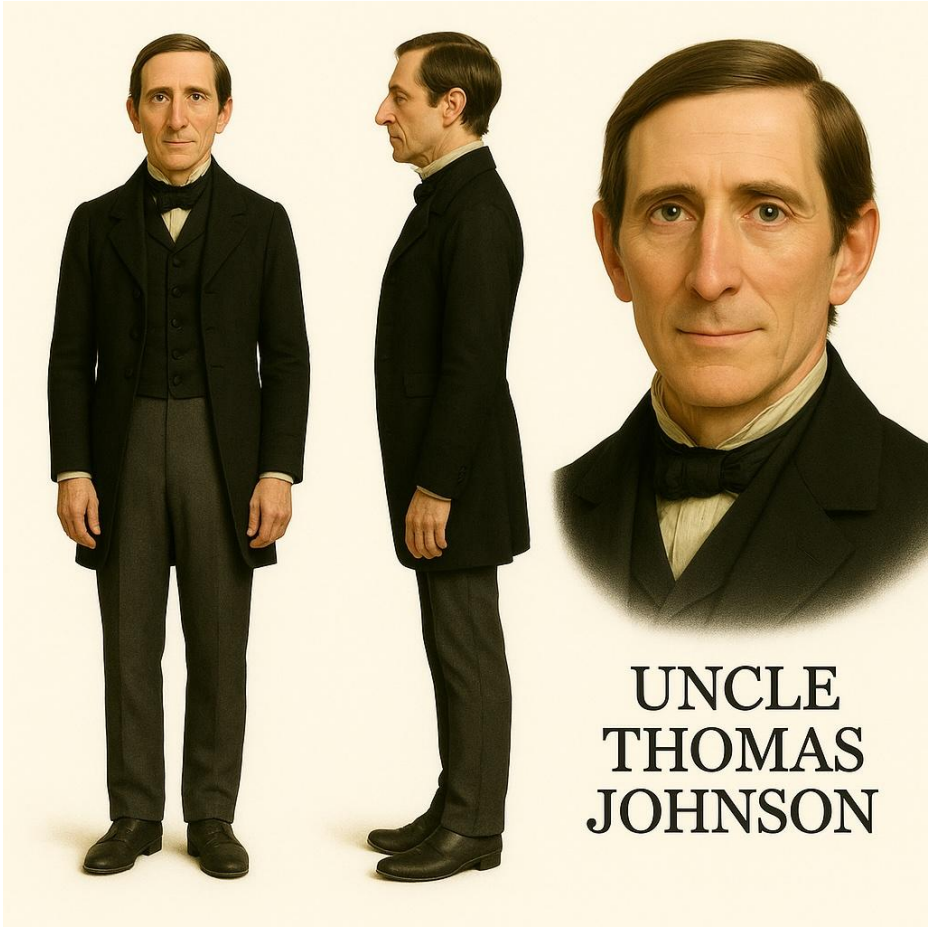
Rebecca S F Prescott aged eight years
Do unto others as you would that others
unto you should do

LOUISA

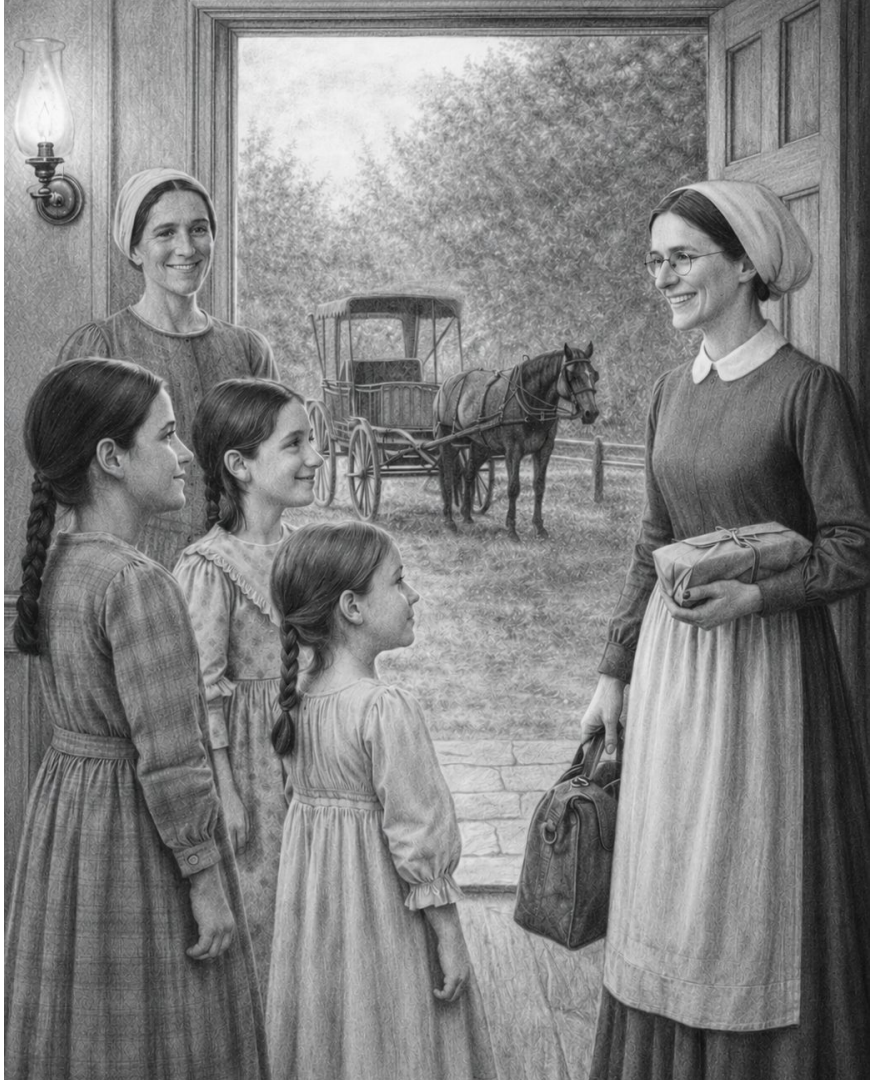
Sallie

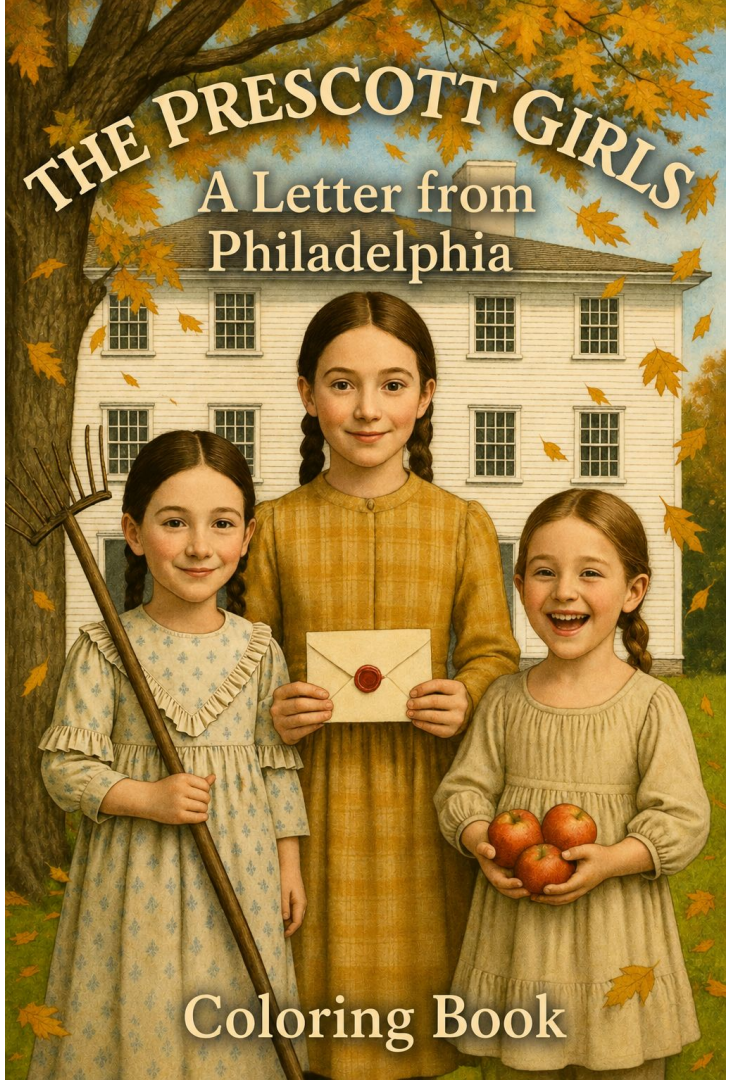
MaineMemory.Net #100363
Collections of Maine Historical Society

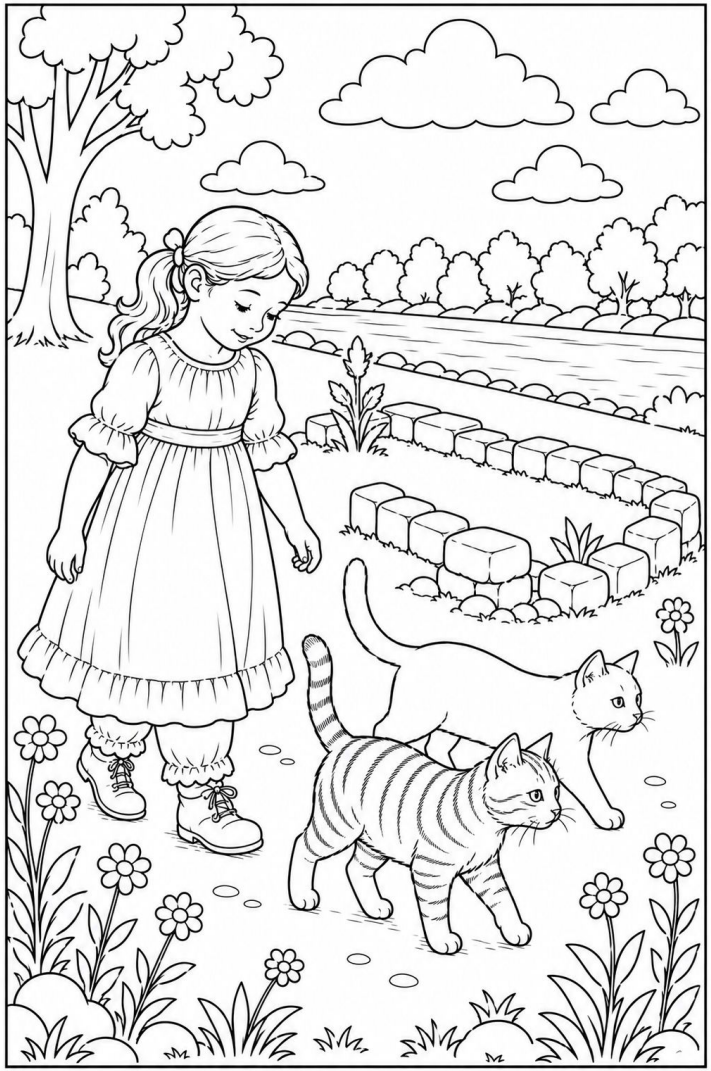



UNCLE
THOMAS
JOHNSON

The Boston Daily Advertiser.
COMMERCIAL




THE PRESCOTT GIRLS
A Letter from Philadelphia
Coloring Book

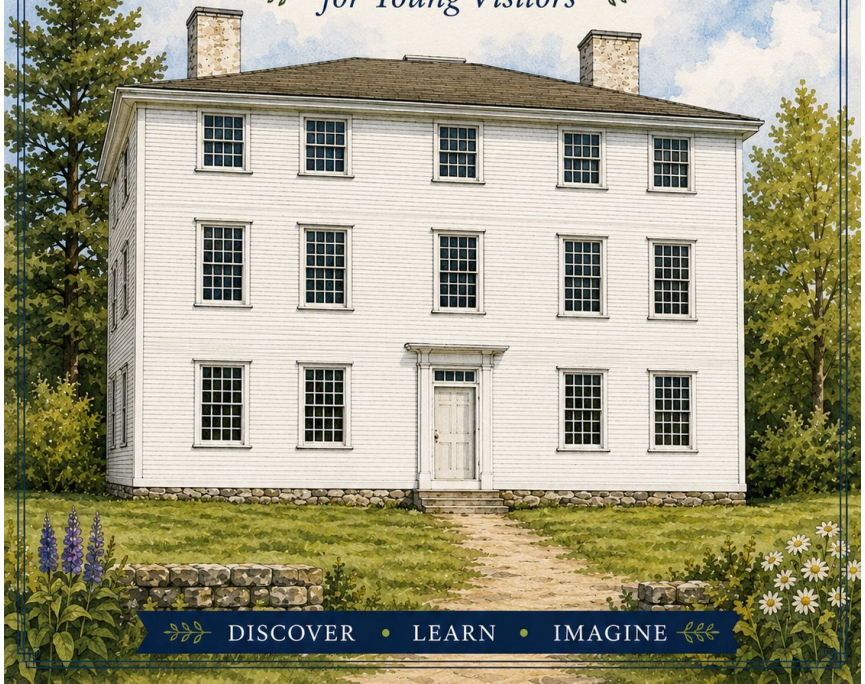


EXPLORE THE

POWNALBOROUGH COURT HOUSE

A CHILDREN'S ACTIVITY GUIDE

for Young Visitors



DISCOVER • LEARN • IMAGINE

POWNALBOROUGH COURT HOUSE

MUSEUM SCAVENGER HUNT

Can you find all of these things in the museum?
Look closely in every room!

Fireplace crane	Spinning wheel	Beckie's sampler	Tea set	Noah's Ark toy
Portrait of Mother	Portrait of Uncle Thomas	Chalk drawing of the Cat	Aunt Nancy and cousin Lydia's portrait	Carving of the Boat in the Tavern
Paisley Shawl	The Snow Sled	Uncle Thomas' Special Chair	Warming pan	Quill pen or ink well
Candle mold	Judge's gavel	Courtroom chair	American flag	Oil lamp
Butter churn	Cradle	Wall clock	School slate	Niddy-Noddy

When you've found them all,
show your card to a staff member
and receive your
JUNIOR HISTORIAN CERTIFICATE!

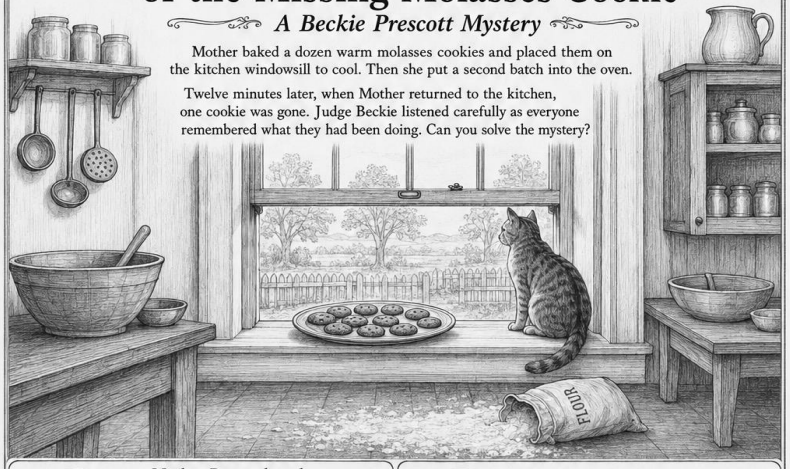
JUNIOR HISTORIAN

The Curious Case of the Missing Molasses Cookie

A Beckie Prescott Mystery

Mother baked a dozen warm molasses cookies and placed them on the kitchen windowsill to cool. Then she put a second batch into the oven.

Twelve minutes later, when Mother returned to the kitchen, one cookie was gone. Judge Beckie listened carefully as everyone remembered what they had been doing. Can you solve the mystery?



Mother Remembered:

"I placed the first batch of molasses cookies on the windowsill to cool and put the second batch into the oven. As Louisa and I went upstairs to bring down the dry laundry, I accidentally spilled flour across the kitchen floor. Twelve minutes later we returned, and I could see from the doorway that one cookie was missing. There were no footprints in the flour."

Louisa Remembered:

Mother and I went upstairs right after she put the second batch into the oven. We brought down the dry laundry. Mother said the second batch was ready about twelve minutes later.

Uncle Thomas Remembered:

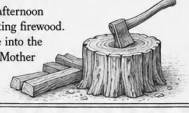
"I spent the afternoon in the post office helping Mr. Dodge, the beekeeper, address a package to his sister.

Sallie Remembered:

"I wanted one of Mother's molasses cookies, but I didn't want to leave footprints in the flour. And I couldn't reach them from outside."

Uncle William Remembered:

"I spent the afternoon outside splitting firewood. I never came into the house while Mother was baking.



Can you solve Judge Beckie's first mystery?

Who took Mother's molasses cookie?

_____

Why do you think so?

_____

_____

★ Beckie believes in truth, fairness, and noticing the little things. Can you solve the mystery?

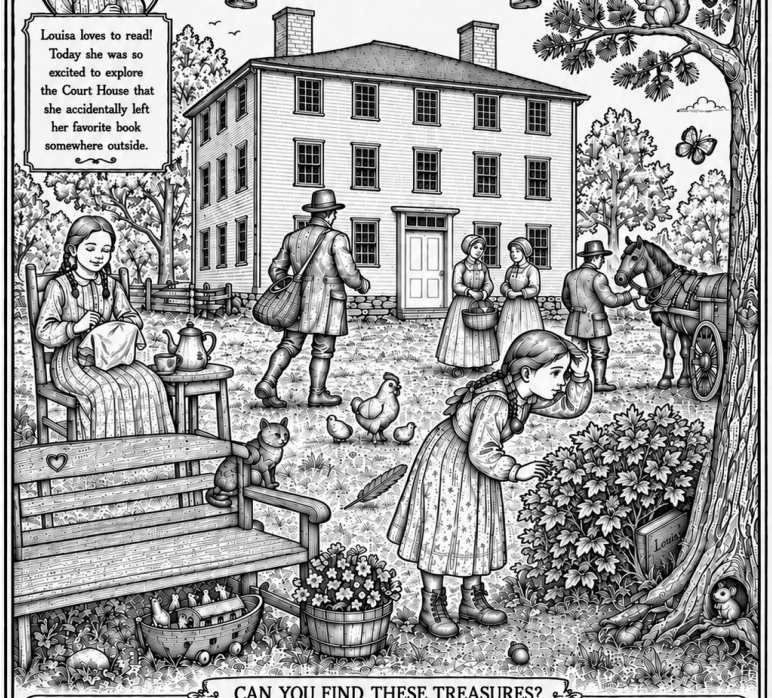
☛ Turn upside-down for the answer: Uncle William through the open window

☆ Help Louisa Find Her Book! ☆

Oh no! Louisa was reading her favorite book while exploring the Pownalborough Court House. She set it down somewhere... and now she can't remember where!

Can you help Louisa find it?

Louisa loves to read! Today she was so excited to explore the Court House that she accidentally left her favorite book somewhere outside.

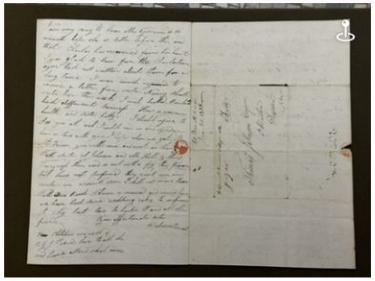
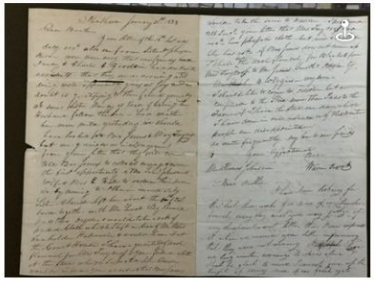
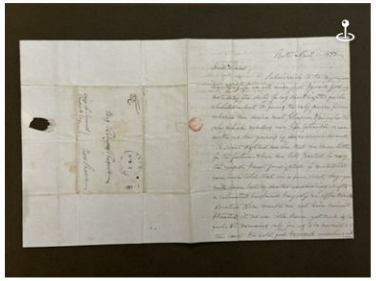


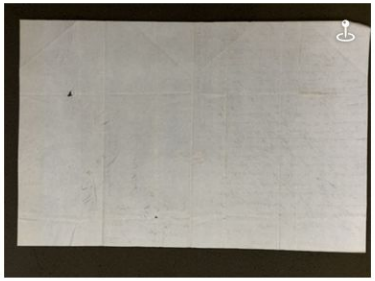
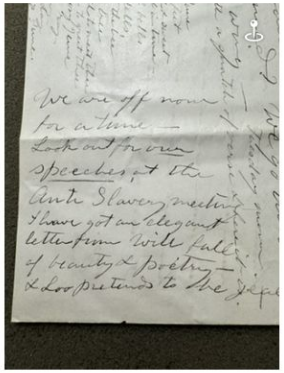
CAN YOU FIND THESE TREASURES?

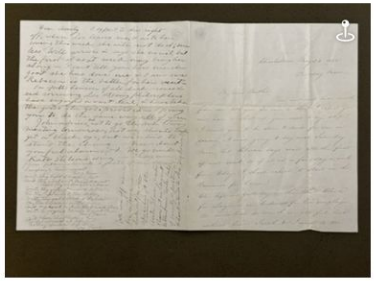
Louisa's book	Squirrel	Noah's Ark toy	Mouse	Pine cone	Feather	Tea cup	Heart	Butterfly	Acorn
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

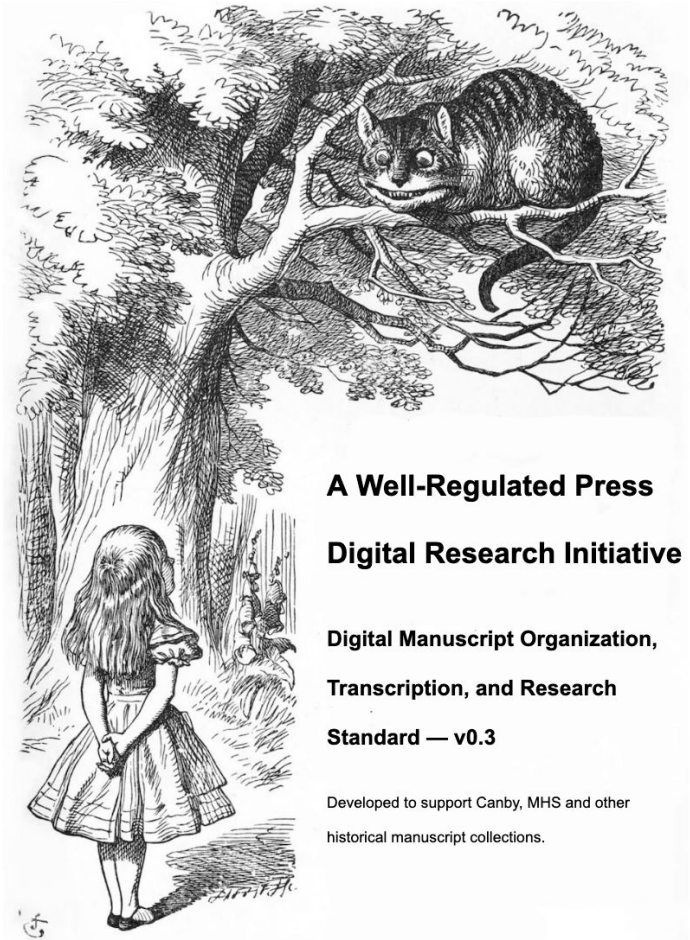
☆ Did you find Louisa's book? It has her name on the cover! ☆

What is in your collection you haven't gotten to?





A Well-Regulated Press Digital Research Initiative

Digital Manuscript Organization, Transcription, and Research Standard — v0.3

Developed to support Canby, MHS and other historical manuscript collections.

Purpose

CopyCAT is intended to create searchable, human-reviewed digital research collections from historical primary-source material.

The immediate working corpus includes nineteenth-century Prescott-family letters, diaries, receipts, school records, account material, and related manuscripts, but the architecture is deliberately repository- and collection-independent.

The project has four linked goals:

1. Preserve and organize archival photographs while retaining their original evidence and provenance.
2. Represent the physical and logical structure of historical documents without forcing photographs, pages, documents, and archival containers into a one-to-one relationship.
3. Use AI as a contextual transcription and research assistant while preserving human verification, revision history, and the original evidence.
4. Produce searchable and reusable research outputs without making those derived products the authoritative archival record.

CopyCAT should:

- Preserve untouched copies of source photographs exactly as captured.
- Preserve repository, collection, box, folder, and institution-specific provenance.
- Preserve the researcher's reconstruction of the physical archival hierarchy.
- Organize photographs into documents, components, logical pages, alternate captures, and ordered text regions.
- Create faithful AI-assisted transcriptions that are verified by people.

Box

Name

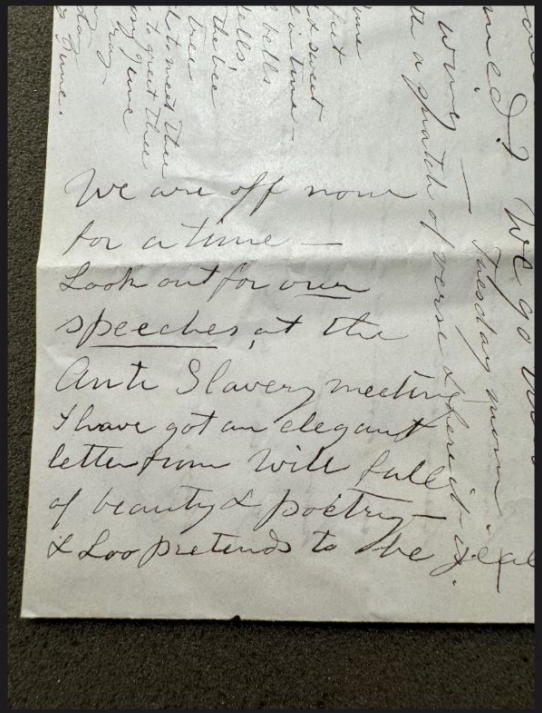
7

Description

Coll. 1924
Series 2: Box 7
Prescott Papers 1833-1849

Identifying image: IMG_7785.jpeg

Save Box | Use Current Image | Remove Image



Document

Number

3

Name

1855 05 22 Letter

Description

Louisa to Mother
Second author currently undetermined

Image 2 of 2: IMG_7594.jpeg

Save Document | Transcribe Document

Since all the downward tracts of time
God's watchful eye surveys
O! who so wise to chuse our lot
And regulate our ways?
Since none can doubt his equal love
Unmeasurably kind
To his unerring gracious will
Be every wish resign'd!
Good when he gives supremely good
Nor less when he denies.
Even crosses from his sovereign hand
Are blessings in disguise.
Elizabeth Bromley 1810

Discovery • Research • Interpretation

From Artifact to Experience

A new approach to historical interpretation, combining artifacts, research, and AI-assisted visualization to help modern audiences engage more directly with the people and places of the past.

A set of 19th-century schoolgirl samplers discovered at auction led to the reconstruction of a 200-year family history. Through research, collaboration with historians and textile experts, and careful interpretation, these

How to Get Started Responsibly

- Find and read the UNESCO-ICOM Report
- Use the survey to assess your museum
- Create an AI account and experiment
- Begin a living AI guidelines document
- Share your findings with others on staff
- Keep humans accountable for AI-generated content

10 Ways to Put AI to Work For You Next Week

Look for Historic Inconsistencies

View your Museum through Multiple Eyes

Families with children
Teenagers
Visitors unfamiliar with the subject
Older visitors
Visitors with limited vision or mobility
School groups
International visitors
Non-native English speakers

The reluctant visitor
Visitors with only 10–20 minutes
Local residents
Tourists
Experts in the subject
People who think the subject isn't for them
Ask AI who it thinks the exhibit was designed for

What Updates would AI Make

Write Signs People Might Actually Read

Historic chair: “George Washington didn't sit here. Neither should you.”
Historic piano: “Please don't play the piano. It already survived the 19th century.”
Antique bed: “No, you may not see if it's comfortable.”
Cannon: “Please don't climb on the cannon. We hate paperwork.”
Rope barrier: “Beyond this point, history becomes considerably more expensive.”
Fragile artifact: “Please don't touch. Your fingerprints aren't part of the collection.”
Historic desk: “Please don't open the drawers. We've already looked.”
Old staircase: “Built before building codes. Please admire its courage from here.”
Do-not-sit exhibit: “If it looks 200 years old, please don't test its weight limit.”
General: “Please help us preserve history by not becoming part of an incident report.”

Help Catalog Your Collection

Review existing exhibit materials, documents,
Draft an object description from a photograph
Transcribe handwritten or typed labels
Suggest keywords and search terms
Standardize inconsistent descriptions
Identify information that may be missing
Turn old catalog cards into structured data
Suggest questions for further research
Create a plain-language description for visitors
Compare similar objects for inconsistencies
Flag records that deserve human review

AI can Help Write Grants

Turn project ideas into a first draft
Match a proposal to grant requirements
Identify missing information
Strengthen the statement of need
Draft project goals and outcomes
Suggest measurable results
Check whether you've answered every application question
Cut a 1,000-word answer to 500 words
Proofread the final application
Ask it to review the proposal as if it were a skeptical grant reviewer

AI can Help With Outreach

Draft a newsletter item
Create social-media posts
Write an event announcement
Draft a press release
Create a website story
Write captions for photographs
Adapt it for different audiences
Suggest questions to encourage engagement
Create a “Did you know?” feature
Turn one piece of research into ten different ways to reach visitors

Raise your hand when you spot the problem

AI will create things that look plausible at first glance

Help Create Activity Sheets

Create scavenger hunts from your exhibits
Draft age-appropriate activity sheets
Create discussion questions
Build teacher guides
Suggest hands-on activities
Create quizzes and games
Adapt material for different grade levels
Connect exhibits to classroom subjects
Create “find this object” challenges
Turn a museum visit into something students continue exploring after they leave

Help Recruit and Train Volunteers

Draft volunteer position descriptions
Create training materials
Turn procedures into simple checklists
Create orientation guides
Draft recruitment messages
Match tasks to different interests and skills
Create FAQs for new volunteers
Turn expert knowledge into instructions others can follow
Draft thank-you and recognition messages
Ask: “What jobs are we doing that a volunteer could help us do?”

Ask AI What You Are Forgetting

Describe an upcoming exhibit, event, or project
Ask what could go wrong
Identify things you haven’t planned for
Look for accessibility issues
Find unanswered visitor questions
Identify assumptions you’re making
Suggest inexpensive improvements
Ask what another museum might do differently
Have it play devil’s advocate
“Here’s our plan. What haven’t we thought of?”

Never

NEVER: Ask AI to Create a Map Without Checking for Accuracy

NEVER: Trust a transcription without checking it against the original.

NEVER: Trust a citation until you've opened the source.

NEVER: Post ANYTHING by AI without human review

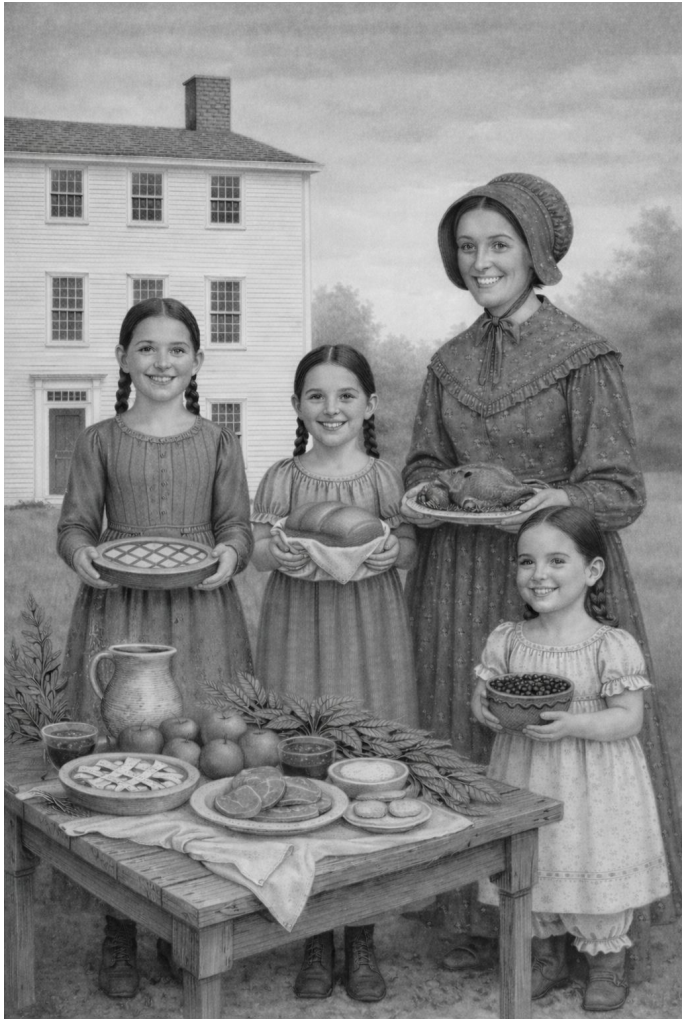
NEVER: Assume a plausible detail is a factual detail.

NEVER: Publish an AI-generated historical image before checking what has been added, removed or changed. (count the fingers)

NEVER: Trust AI to write your bio… actually it's much better now.

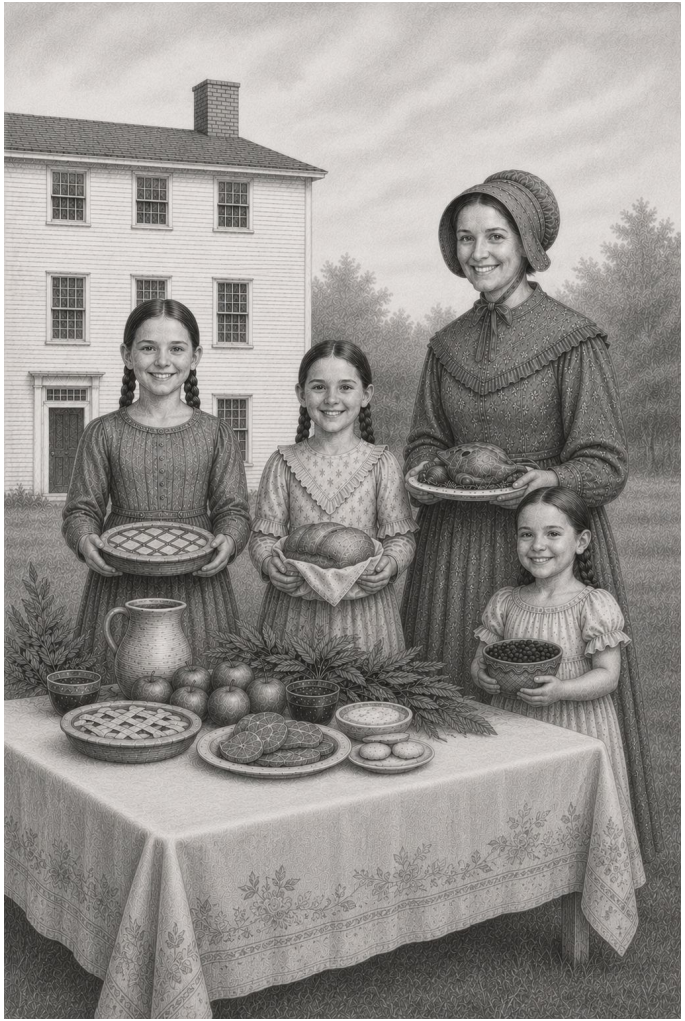
AI Complexity Budget

The more complex the task, the more likely the error



Another show of hands

What is the issue?



Sometimes You
Will Have to Punt!

For museums, AI changes what is possible.

Our responsibility to history hasn't changed. Our ability to share it has.

Don’t Forget
Who is the Historian

You Are